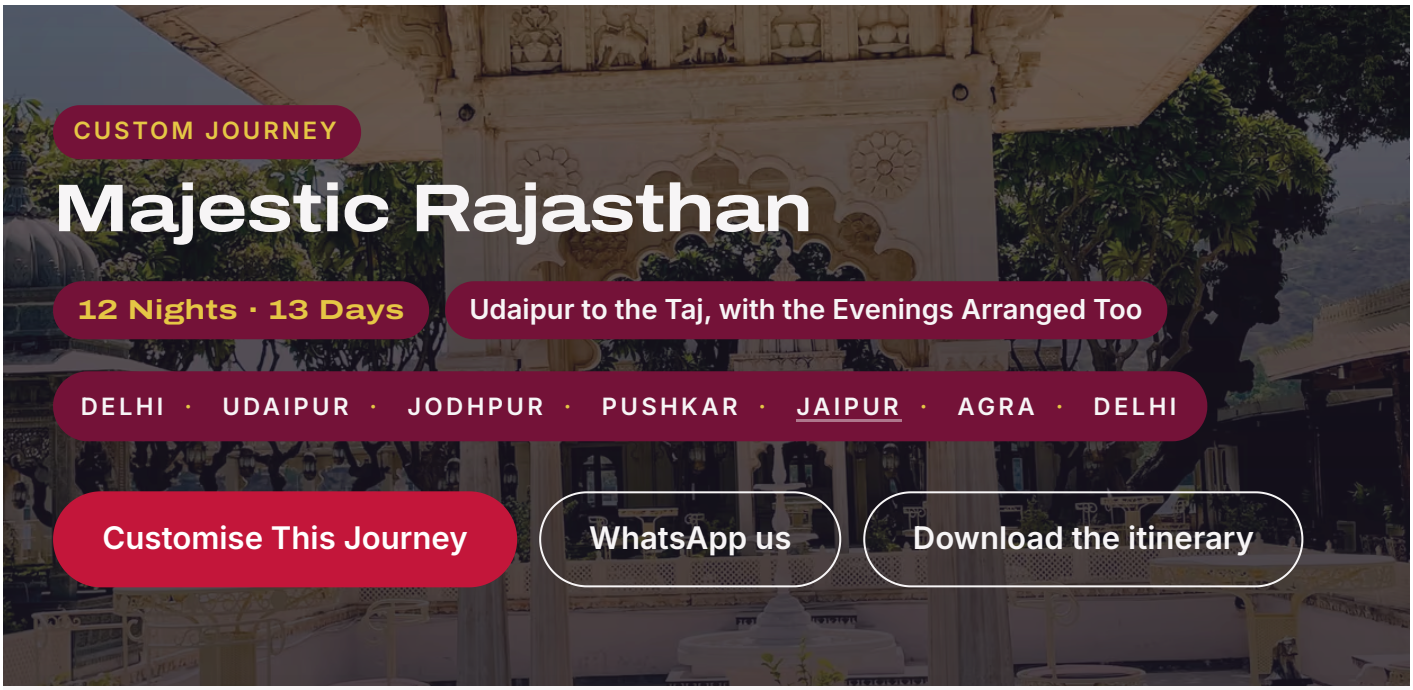
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DURATION
12 Nights · 13 Days

ROUTE
Delhi return

PACE
Moderate

BEST SEASON
October to March

IDEAL FOR
First-Timers, Couples, Families

Majestic Rajasthan is the western beauty of India, and in particular its rural side: a land of bright colour, mighty fortresses and ornamented palaces built by rulers who governed the state for centuries, whose architecture and miniature painting are the Rajputs' lasting legacy. Thirteen days from Delhi through Udaipur, Jodhpur, Pushkar and Jaipur to Agra, it is a classic first journey to India.

What makes it different from the other Rajasthan routes we run is the evenings. Most itineraries stop at the monuments; this one goes on to a boat on Lake Pichola, a village fair at Chokhi Dhani, a cooking lesson in an Agra home, a yoga class before Amer, and the stage story of the Taj the night before you see it. It is the version for travellers who want the days *and* the nights arranged, and every one of them can be dropped or swapped.

Journey Highlights

- **Drift** across Lake Pichola in the evening to the island palace of Jag Niwas, then walk Udaipur's lanes with a guide who knows its artisans by name.
- **Visit** a Bishnoi village by jeep outside Jodhpur, a community that has protected its trees and wildlife for five centuries.
- **Cook** with an Indian family in Agra and learn a Rajasthani meal in Jaipur, then eat what you made.
- **Spend** an evening at Chokhi Dhani, a village fair recreated nightly with folk music, puppetry, acrobats and dinner.
- **Begin** a Jaipur morning with yoga, and end an Agra evening at Mohabbat the Taj, the stage story of the building you will see at dawn.
- **Descend** the Chand Baori stepwell at Abhaneri and walk Fatehpur Sikri on the road between Jaipur and Agra.
- **Learn** to tie a sari, have your palm read, and see a Bollywood film in a Jaipur cinema. The small things people remember.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Delhi**	Arrival in the capital
Day 02	**Delhi**	Old and New Delhi; a henna evening
Day 03	**Delhi to Udaipur**	Fly to the lake city; an evening boat on Pichola
Day 04	**Udaipur**	City Palace, Jagdish Temple and a heritage walk

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 05	Udaipur to Jodhpur	The Jain temples at Ranakpur en route
Day 06	Jodhpur	Mehrangarh, Jaswant Thada and a Bishnoi village by jeep
Day 07	Jodhpur to Pushkar	To the desert lake town
Day 08	Pushkar to Jaipur	The Brahma temple, a cooking experience, Chokhi Dhani
Day 09	Jaipur	Morning yoga, Amer Fort, City Palace and shopping
Day 10	Jaipur to Agra	Elephant sanctuary, Abhaneri, Fatehpur Sikri; Mohabbat the Taj
Day 11	Agra	The Taj Mahal and Agra Fort; a cooking class at a family home
Day 12	Agra to Delhi	Akshardham on the way back to the capital
Day 13	Delhi	Transfer to the airport

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Delhi: Arrival

Met on arrival and transferred to your hotel. Delhi has been inhabited since the sixth century BC and has been the capital of many kingdoms, destroyed and rebuilt so often it is called the city of cities. The Mughals shaped its food as much as its skyline, and Mughlai cooking began here; Old Delhi is a maze of lanes and old buildings, New Delhi a grid of broad roads. The evening is free.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 02 Delhi: Two Cities and a Henna Evening

Old Delhi first, Shah Jahan's city of 1639: Raj Ghat and the Gandhi museum, a drive past the Red Fort and Chandni Chowk, and the Jama Masjid. A rickshaw through the market is optional and worth it. In the afternoon, Qutub Minar, built in 1192 and a UNESCO site, Humayun's Tomb, India Gate, a drive past Parliament and the presidential estate, and the Lakshminarayan Temple. In the evening, a mehndi artist comes to the hotel. Henna has been used to decorate hands in India, the Near East and North Africa since antiquity, and the pattern lasts a week or two.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 03 Udaipur: The City of Lakes

Fly · Delhi to Udaipur

Transfer to the airport for the flight to Udaipur, met on arrival and taken to your hotel. Udaipur was the capital of Mewar, founded by Rana Udai Singh in 1559; its rulers, the Suryavanshi descendants of the sun, head all the Rajput clans, and Maharana Pratap, who fought Akbar at Haldighati in 1576, was born here. In the evening, a boat on Lake Pichola (four kilometres long, ringed by hills, palaces, temples and bathing ghats) with a stop at the island palace of Jag Niwas.

Overnight in Udaipur

Day 04 Udaipur: The Palace and the Lanes

The City Palace on the bank of Pichola, begun by Udai Singh in 1559 and added to for four centuries; then the Jagdish Temple, one of the city's largest, built in the Indo-Aryan style for Vishnu; a drive around Fateh Sagar lake; the Bhartiya Lok Kala Mandal folk museum; and Sahelion ki Bari, the garden of the maidens. In the afternoon, a guided heritage walk through the real Udaipur: the lanes, the bazaars, and the jewellers, potters and bamboo-workers who still work in them, with a city explorer whose knowledge of the place is infectious.

Overnight in Udaipur

Day 05 Ranakpur: The Road to Jodhpur

Drive · via Ranakpur

North to the Jain temples of Ranakpur, ninety-eight kilometres from Udaipur. The fifteenth-century Chaumukha temple, in marble, is dedicated to Adinath, the first Tirthankara, and is built of more than twenty halls on 1,444 pillars, no two of them alike. If time allows, the Surya Temple beside it. Then on to Jodhpur, the sun city and the blue city, founded by Rao Jodha in 1459 and once a trading post on the road from Delhi to Gujarat. The rest of the day is at leisure.

Overnight in Jodhpur

Day 06 Jodhpur: Mehrangarh and a Bishnoi Village

Mehrangarh in the morning, one of the largest forts in India on a sandstone hill above the city, with the Moti Mahal and Phool Mahal inside its walls. Then Jaswant Thada, the marble memorial of 1889 that glows when the sun is on it, and the Umaid gardens with the Government Museum. In the afternoon, a jeep safari to a Bishnoi village, a community whose faith has protected its trees and its animals for five hundred years, and whose welcome to visitors goes back to the maharajas who first brought them.

Overnight in Jodhpur

Day 07 Pushkar: The Desert Lake

Drive · about 6 hours

A long drive east to Pushkar, a small town of temples and ghats around a holy lake at the edge of the desert. The afternoon is free: the ghats at sunset, and the bazaar that runs down to them.

Overnight in Pushkar

Day 08 Pushkar to Jaipur: A Cooking Lesson and a Village Fair

Drive · Pushkar to Jaipur

A tour of Pushkar, one of the most sacred pilgrimage sites for Hindus and home to the only temple in the country dedicated to Brahma, then the road to Jaipur. The pink city, painted for the Prince of Wales in the nineteenth century, was founded by Maharaja Jai Singh more than two hundred and sixty years ago. In the afternoon, an authentic culinary experience: the basic ingredients, the simple nuances that make an Indian dish work, and a meal cooked by you with a little help. In the evening, Chokhi Dhani, a Rajasthani village fair recreated nightly: folk dancers, a magic show, puppets, an acrobat on a bamboo pole, an astrologer and a fortune-telling parrot, with dinner included.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 09 Jaipur: Yoga, Amer and the Bazaars

An early yoga class, then breakfast and a full day in the city. Amer Fort first, the earlier capital, built by Raja Man Singh in red sandstone and marble around four courtyards: the Suraj Pol gate, the Sila Devi temple, the two audience halls, the Sheesh Mahal and the water-cooled Sukh Niwas. Then the seven-storey City Palace in its blend of Mughal, Rajput and European styles, the Jantar Mantar observatory, and a drive past the Hawa Mahal. A tour of Jaipur is not complete without its shops: textiles, carpets, precious and semi-precious stones, jewellery, and miniature painting. This is also the day for the smaller things: learning to tie a sari in a shop, a palm reading, a Bollywood film in a local cinema.

Explore Jaipur →

Overnight in Jaipur

Day 10 Abhaneri and Fatehpur Sikri: The Road to Agra

Drive · via Abhaneri and Fatehpur Sikri

A morning at an elephant sanctuary outside the city, feeding the animals, bathing them, and walking alongside them around the farm. Then the road to Agra with two stops. Abhaneri, once Abha Nagri, the city of brightness, is famous for the stepwells the region built to harvest rain; Chand Baori, in front of the Harshat Mata Temple, is among the largest and deepest in India. Fatehpur Sikri, Akbar's abandoned capital and a UNESCO site, follows: the Jama Masjid, Salim Chishti's tomb, the Panch Mahal and the Buland Darwaza. In Agra this evening, Mohabbat the Taj, a stage play of the love of Shah Jahan and Mumtaz Mahal and the twenty-two years of craftsmanship behind the building.

Overnight in Agra

Day 11 Agra: The Taj, the Fort and a Family Kitchen

The Taj Mahal in the morning: white marble on the Yamuna, built by Shah Jahan between 1631 and 1648 for Mumtaz Mahal, and closed on Fridays. Then Agra Fort, the sixteenth-century UNESCO site with the Khas Mahal, the Jahangir Palace and the two audience halls. Agra is famous for marble inlay, and there is time for it. In the evening, a cooking class in an Indian home (the lady of the house demonstrating several dishes) and dinner with the family, which is the best introduction to how people actually live.

Overnight in Agra

Day 12 Delhi: Akshardham on the Way Back

Drive · Agra to Delhi

After breakfast, the road back to Delhi and a visit to Swaminarayan Akshardham, closed on Mondays: a temple complex of carved sandstone and marble built by thousands of volunteers, with more than two hundred statues of the spiritual figures of Hinduism and exhibitions on the life and teachings of Lord Swaminarayan. Check in to your Delhi hotel for the last night.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 13 Delhi: Departure

Transfer to the airport in time for your onward flight.

Departure

What's included

- Twelve nights on a twin-sharing basis with breakfast
- Twelve breakfasts and dinners as set out in the programme
- The domestic flight from Delhi to Udaipur
- Transfers and tours by private car; assistance on arrival and departure
- Monument entry fees and an English-speaking local guide for the sightseeing
- The evening boat ride on Lake Pichola and the heritage walking tour in Udaipur
- The Bishnoi village jeep safari in Jodhpur
- Chokhi Dhani village evening with dinner, the yoga session, the cooking experience, the sari lesson, palmistry, a Bollywood film and the shopping tour in Jaipur
- The elephant sanctuary morning, and the Abhaneri stepwell
- Mohabbat the Taj, the cooking class and the heritage walk in Agra
- Akshardham Temple in Delhi
- All applicable taxes

Typical inclusions for a journey of this shape. The final list is confirmed in your custom quote.

Not included

> Insurance

> Lunches

> Tips

> Camera fees, and any expense not named above

Practical notes

Best time to visit

October to March. The state is uncomfortable from April until the monsoon, and Pushkar's lake and Udaipur's are at their best after the rains have filled them.

Getting there

Delhi's Indira Gandhi International (DEL) is the arrival and departure point; the Delhi–Udaipur leg is a short domestic flight, included.

Ideal duration

Thirteen days, because this itinerary is built around evenings as much as mornings (the boat, the village fair, the cooking, the stage show), and those cannot be compressed.

Pace

Moderate. One long drive (Jodhpur to Pushkar, about six hours), one flight, and a programme that fills most evenings. Tell us if you would rather leave some of them free.